

distros that came out last year (including Ubuntu 9.10), and none of their graphics would load on it. My immediate reaction? So much for the claims, send this laptop back!

Meanwhile, Ubuntu 10.04 beta had just hit the mirrors. Wait a sec! This one worked. In fact, it booted into the GUI with the correct 1366x768-pixel resolution. Whoa! Now, I could only pin the earlier problem to the newer processor architecture—Intel Core i3—that comes with integrated GPU [more here: http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Intel_Core#Core_i3]. Since this was not the case earlier, naturally there is a possibility that the older kernels on those distros didn't have support for this newly integrated trendiness :-)

Anyway, graphics is just a basic thing—and has become quite old-school nowadays, unless you're stuck with a weirdo GPU from NVIDIA or ATI. As Boudhayan's article notes, there could be a lot of other issues, which some of us might only be able to figure out later on.

To be honest, I haven't done much research at all. However, I tested the latest betas of both Fedora 13 and Mandriva 2010 Spring, and, just like the latest Ubuntu, the other two also supported everything out of the box, including Wi-Fi (yes, this one is powered by an Atheros chip—AR9285 Wireless Network Adapter—for a change).

The look

The CR620 looks, well, like a standard laptop—nothing too great, neither is it ugly. For a 39.6-cm (15.6-inch) LCD size, the dimensions of 37.4x24.75x3.5 cm mean there's hardly any unnecessary extra plasticky space. In fact, the increase in the length of the laptop due to the 16:9 wide-screen display has made way for inclusion of a numeric keypad in the keyboard—makes life easier if you play with numbers a lot. Besides, with the six-cell battery power, it weighs only 2.5 kg—which I won't exactly call lightweight, but it isn't too bad to carry around.

The exterior is black plastic, with the top portion having a glossy finish with thin grey horizontal stripes—looks decently



The 103-key chiclet keyboard includes a numeric pad too

elegant, but is also a fingerprint magnet. The screen sits on two sturdy hinges, and the good part is that it is possible to turn it at an angle of more than 180 degrees.

The LCD has decent clarity, although viewing it at angles could be a problem (as expected). The webcam and the integrated mic are centrally located atop the LCD.

I must say that the best feature of this laptop is its chiclet keyboard, which makes typing on it a breeze. Although 103 keys mean there's hardly any breathing space, I've got to admit that the placement of keys is decent and doesn't need much getting used to. Some keys are placed at non-standard locations, though.

The touch-pad is placed somewhat towards the left. This makes sense, because a numeric keypad on the extreme right means that your right hand rests a bit away from the RHS margin while composing a document, unlike in case of laptops without num-pads. The touch-pad's interface was not quite comfortable to use. In fact, scrolling pages using it was very cumbersome. It offers too much resistance, and I wish they could have made the experience a bit smoother.

Right below the touch-pad you have the status LEDs for Bluetooth, Wi-Fi, sleep state, battery, hard disk access, Num Lock, Caps Lock and Scroll Lock, in that order. I do feel the frequency of the blinks while in sleep mode (suspend) is a bit too intense, and can scare you out of your sleep in the middle of the night :-)

The stereo speakers are mounted on the front, which means that if the laptop is on your lap, your tummy might block the sound output—not a very clever decision. I would have preferred them to be in the horizontal empty space above the keyboard. Also, while watching movies, I kept wishing for a way to turn up the volume higher than the maximum possible. That said, the output quality at max volume was clear, with no significant jarring—not quite the case with cheaper models from other vendors.

The left side of the laptop has the Express Card slot, a card reader, 3.5-mm headphone and mic ports, an RJ-45 Ethernet



Apart from one USB 2.0 port that's available on the RHS, rest of the ports concentrate on the left and rear side